The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AP

Pete Hegseth claimed that **America** and **Israel** would soon gain control of Iranian airspace and deliver “death and destruction all day long”. America’s secretary of war said the conflict was entering a new phase with “larger waves” of attacks. Mr Hegseth also said that a US Navy submarine sank an Iranian warship in the Indian Ocean. He called it America’s first sinking of an enemy ship with a torpedo since the second world war.

America’s **Senate** rejected a measure that would require Congress to approve Donald Trump’s military operations in Iran. The outcome was expected; the House of Representatives will vote on Thursday. Meanwhile **Iran’s** foreign ministry dismissed the White House’s claim that America’s pre-emptive attack was necessary because Mr Trump had a “feeling” that Iran would strike first. Mr Trump was acting “on behalf of Israel”, the ministry said.

Azerbaijan is weighing action against Iran after a drone attack on its territory. The Azerbaijani defence ministry blamed Iran for the “acts of aggression”; Iran rejected the claims and pointed the finger at Israel. Iranian **Kurdish** groups based in **Iraq** were also reportedly considering entering the fight. The groups have been

engaged in a decades-long conflict with Iran's regime in an attempt to win greater autonomy.

Oil prices continued to command high prices because of the war in Iran. Brent crude, the global benchmark, rose by around 3% to $84 a barrel. The International Energy Agency, an energy watchdog, warned that prolonged disruption to oil supply "could flip the market into a deficit". China reportedly ordered oil refiners to suspend exports of diesel and gasoline.

BYD, the world's largest **electric-vehicle maker** by volume, reported weaker domestic sales as demand in China slowed. Purchases fell by more than a third in January and February, compared with the previous year. The two-week Lunar New Year holiday in February partly explains the lower sales. But sales at rival Chinese carmakers, including Leapmotor and Xiaomi, rose during the same period.

China set an uninspiring growth target for 2026 of 4.5-5% at the National People's Congress, its rubber-stamp parliament. That is its lowest target since 1991. Last year it aimed for 5% growth (which, to little surprise, it said it hit exactly). The modest target comes despite persistent deflation and high youth unemployment, both proof that China should aim higher.

Ukraine's president, Volodymyr Zelensky, said a new round of trilateral talks with America and **Russia** had been postponed because of the war in the Middle East. The discussions had been expected to take place this week in Abu Dhabi before Iranian strikes targeted the Gulf region. Meanwhile, President Vladimir Putin accused Ukraine of sinking a Russian tanker in the Mediterranean in a drone attack.

Figure of the day: 18m, the number of people who migrated to America from southern and eastern Europe between 1890 and 1919. Read our history of immigration to America.

Photograph: Reuters

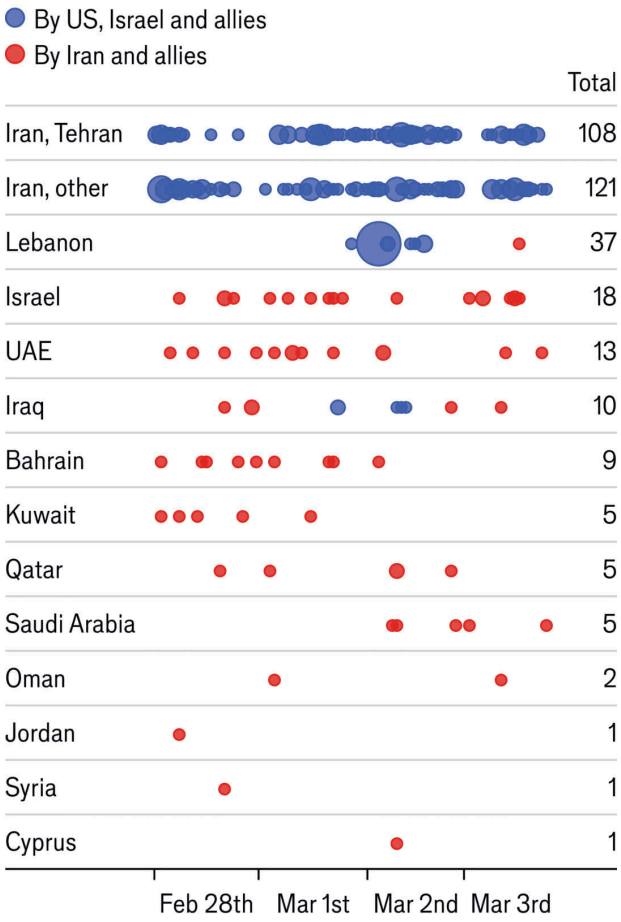
The war’s next phase

As America and Israel prepared to attack Iran, military planners drew up three lists of targets. The shortest was of sites to be attacked in the first wave of strikes on February 28th, including the office of the supreme leader, Ali Khamenei. The next was of high-priority targets for the first 100 hours of the war. The generals were uncertain whether Donald Trump would want to keep fighting beyond that point.

Now they are on a much longer list of lower-priority targets. These include thousands of military bases, factories and sites linked to the *basij*, the regime’s militia. The aim is either to grind the regime into submission or bring millions onto the streets to topple it. But the global economy is taking a major hit as energy prices rise. And America’s regional allies are running short of missile interceptors to fend off Iranian strikes. The question is whether Mr Trump will double down, or call time.

Epic fury

Location of reported strikes



Sources: Institute for the Study of War; AEI's Critical Threats Project

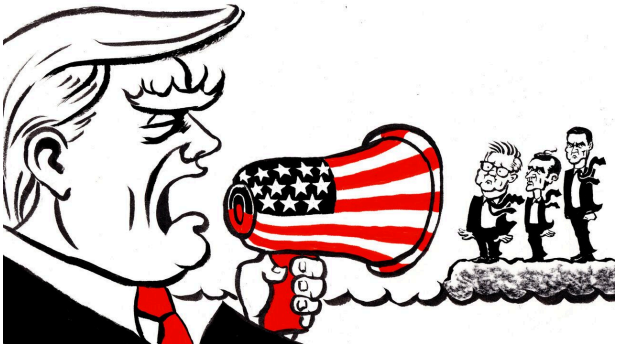


Illustration: David Simonds

What Iran means for transatlantic relations

Donald Trump has never bothered to hide his disdain for what he regards as his woke, feckless, peacenik European allies. And as if to confirm his worst fears, France's president has publicly condemned the American and Israeli attacks on Iran, for breaching international law; Spain's prime minister, Pedro Sánchez, called them "a disaster". He refused to allow American planes to take off from jointly operated bases, as did Britain's Sir Keir Starmer at first. America's president threatened to sever trade with Spain and trashed Sir Keir as "no Winston Churchill". Ouch.

Britain eventually gave America permission to use its bases, if only for defensive operations, and is sending a warship to Cyprus, where it has a base. Britain, after all, has the most to lose from a rupture in the so-called special relationship. France is also sending an aircraft-carrier to the Mediterranean. European countries were already preparing for a future less reliant on America. This nasty spat will only hasten it.

Photograph: AFP

A troubling leak at Anthropic

Anthropic is scrambling to rescue its already rocky relationship with the Trump administration, after a memo from the AI lab's head, Dario Amodei, was leaked. Anthropic fell out with the Department of War over demands that it agree to "all legal uses" of its AI systems. Mr Amodei blanched at the firm's systems potentially being used to make autonomous weapons or for mass domestic surveillance.

In the note, Mr Amodei blamed the spat on his failure to lavish "dictator-style praise" on the president. But he reserved his strongest criticisms for his former boss Sam Altman. Mr Altman's firm, OpenAI, struck a deal with the Pentagon shortly after the government threatened to classify Anthropic a "supply chain risk"—a troubling commercial restriction.

OpenAI admitted its deal looked opportunistic, but insisted it had set its own guardrails for the use of its AI. Mr Amodei called that claim "mendacious", saying the technical safeguards OpenAI proposed to protect against mass surveillance were "safety theatre" and that the company's employees were "a gullible bunch". His outburst is unlikely to help Anthropic's reported bid to renegotiate with the Pentagon.

Photograph: AP

Nepal looks to the future

On Thursday Nepal holds its first elections since a student-led revolution in September forced KP Sharma Oli to resign as prime minister. The uprising, branded a “Gen Z movement”, was caused by widespread dissatisfaction with Nepal’s three dominant parties, which ruled for the past two decades and left a legacy of ingrained corruption and a lack of jobs.

Several of the Gen Z-protest leaders have joined a fourth party, known as the Rastriya Swatantra Party. It has captured the attention of voters young and old, and is expected to sweep to victory with Balendra Shah, the 35-year-old mayor of Kathmandu, the capital, becoming prime minister. He is running in the same constituency as Mr Oli, who believes he was wronged in the uprising. Mr Shah impressed voters in Kathmandu by improving governance. His supporters are hoping he will do the same nationwide.

Photograph: May James/ZUMA Press Wire/Shutterstock

China’s JD.com goes global

British shoppers will soon be able to have groceries delivered by Joybuy, a subsidiary of JD.com, a Chinese e-commerce group. China’s bustling online-retail industry is becoming more successful globally. Americans love shopping on Shein, a fast-fashion outlet (even if some European governments are wary of the company). And TikTok Shop is still run by China’s ByteDance despite a recent deal for the video-sharing app’s main algorithm in America to be controlled domestically.

But when JD released earnings on Thursday, investors were more focused on the company’s business in China. JD reported a net loss of 2.7bn yuan ($393m) in the final three months of 2025, its first such quarterly loss since 2022. It has been embroiled in a delivery war with its domestic rivals since early 2025. Moreover, the group has not fully jumped on the AI bandwagon. Those issues are dampening investors’ excitement, whatever flashy plans the group has for global expansion.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: What type of footwear, which raised the user's height, was very popular in the 1970s?

Wednesday: Arturo Toscanini, Leopold Stokowski and Claudio Abbado all achieved fame in what role?

Common sense is the instinct for truth.

Max Jacob